about it only two hours later by fellow Congress MP Sandeep Dikshit, via a short email and SMS. ‘As the East Delhi MP, I was very worried about Anna being arrested in a locality in my constituency. I knew it was a mistake and asked Rahul to intervene,’ Dikshit told me later. Rahul, who was in Parliament, acted immediately, ringing up the home minister P. Chidambaram to have the arrest order revoked. The damage, though, had been done. Anna Hazare had been transformed from a relatively benign social activist into a heroic figure of national significance. Support for him began to swell as he shifted his fast site to the Ramlila Maidan. For the next thirteen days, Anna Hazare became a Mahatma Gandhi-like larger-than-life figure dominating television screens and the national discourse. The government was on the mat.

A week into the agitation, with no sign of a breakthrough, the government was getting increasingly desperate. A back-room negotiation team led by Pranab Mukherjee, which included Union minister Salman Khurshid and the Delhi MP Sandeep Dikshit, was attempting to broker a settlement with Team Anna. At one of the meetings between the two sides a suggestion was made—why doesn’t Rahul Gandhi come to Ramlila Maidan, go on stage, meet Anna Hazare and offer him a glass of juice to break his fast? An assurance from Rahul that a Lok Pal legislation was to be enacted would be enough for Anna to end his fast. Rahul, the negotiators were assured by Team Anna, could take all the credit.

An excited Dikshit, who had played a key role in the negotiations because of his previous links with members of Anna’s inner circle, promptly sent another email to Rahul detailing the possible compromise solution. Only this time he got no response. ‘It could have been the biggest moment of Rahul’s political career, when he could have claimed a major victory,’ says Dikshit today, a touch wistfully. Adds another Congress leader, ‘Think about it, the image of Rahul giving juice to Anna would have been plastered on every newspaper and television screen. It would have been the most enduring image of the times and would have established Rahul’s credentials as an anti-establishment crusader.’